

Discreet Combustion 4



A Must-Have For 3ds Max Users

Discreet's Combustion has come a long way since its first days as a tool that would normally be used only with 3D Studio Max (3ds Max). Today, Combustion can do for video what Photoshop can do for images, and it's a strong competitor to Adobe's After Effects in this area.

Firing Up

Combustion's interface is a tad unconventional, and beginners will find themselves lost for a bit, but some tinkering and many silly mistakes later, one finds that it's really quite intuitive. If you have used After Effects, though, getting used to Combustion might be a little more difficult.

With Combustion, you can fix most problems with videos—eliminate camera jitter, colour correction, and “key” out backgrounds from scenes and add new backgrounds in their place. It's also a very powerful tool to create 2D and 3D video composites, and integrates tightly with 3ds Max to add some amazing post-production special effects to your 3ds Max scenes.

With some incredible particle and fire effects, Combustion makes up for 3ds Max's shortcomings in the special-effects department, and there are more than enough presets to keep you happy for a long time. Creating these effects in 3ds Max would have been too resource hungry (not that they aren't in Combustion), and this saves a lot of time.

Diamond Keys

New to Combustion 4 is the Diamond Keyer, which is a much more powerful tool to remove backgrounds from videos than the existing Discreet Keyer. It's also extremely simple to use and much lighter on resources than the multitude of operators one would use to get the same effect. With the inclusion of this, Combustion's abilities

now begin to approach those of the higher-end compositors such as Flint, Flame, and Inferno.

The G-Buffer Builder

Before Combustion 4, creating depth-of-field effects would be extremely torturous if you didn't use Discreet's Rich Pixel Format (RPF)—3ds Max's rendering format that saves even depth information—but now, Combustion comes with the new

G-Buffer builder, which lets you use its paint tool to define the different

levels of depth in the video; now, creating stunning depth-based effects are easy to create even in non-3ds Max scenes.

Time-warping

Another major improvement is the Timewarper, which creates much more convincing slow-motion, speed-up and other time-distortion effects. Instead of simply changing the frame-rate, Combustion now renders intermediate frames to give much smoother transitions between keyframes and finer control over the effects.

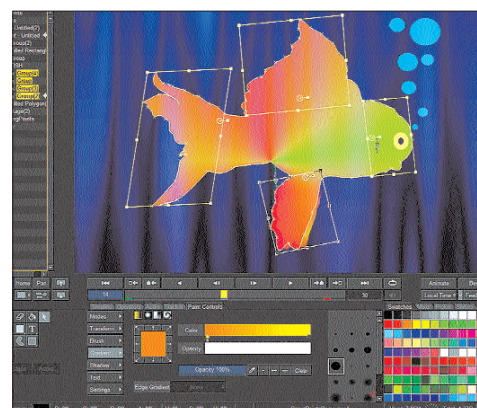
Capsules

Capsules let you save the whole gamut of effects you just created as a single effect and save it for application in another project, or even share it with friends!

The Rig

While Combustion will run on a machine with 512 MB of RAM, you'll need at least 1 GB to get some productivity out of it, and even more if you plan on using it for more high-end effects. A dual-core processor would also make it quite happy.

If you are a 3ds Max user, Combustion is an application you don't want to be without. If you're looking to make your big break into compositing and special effects, this should be on your list. Unfortunately for Maya users, Autodesk still hasn't introduced support for it despite taking over Alias, but that should come soon.



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Rating

